members to win over her mother, who herself encouraged her daughter to keep working.

Would she have gone ahead with the marriage had her mother continued to oppose it? No, she would have dropped it, Gunvanti tells me. She is as unwilling as the other women I've met to ignore her family's wishes. Yet Gunvanti is far more optimistic than Sita or Aaliyah. She, too, has moved around India, but in her case because she followed jobs that she wanted after graduating from university with a degree in classical singing. In fact, she turned down a more lucrative offer in order to come to Delhi to work at the same place as her then fiancé.

She and her husband continue to work together, and she says he will leave it entirely up to her to decide whether or not to hold a job. She clearly is very much in love, and her eyes sparkle when I suggest she is luckier than many of the other women that I've met. Many of her friends were also married in love matches, she tells me, though she recognizes they are still a minority. Like Aaliyah, she focuses on personal relations and doesn't raise national issues of violence against women or broader discrimination.

So given her fortunate situation, I ask, what does she think would do the most to help women in India? Education, she replies immediately, and having a job. "If you bring your own status to a marriage, then the man will respect you more," she asserts, even though she knows that many, if not most, women continue to face restrictions placed on them by family or husbands. "But [the prevalence of such restrictions is] starting to change."

India is indeed changing, though unevenly. Nearly everyone I talk with, male or female, stresses that India must build up its national strength, meaning its economy, in order to play a larger role in the world, especially in the Indo-Pacific region. All the young women I meet are part of that strength, yet many will undoubtedly drop out of the workforce. Government or business doesn't seem to be the hindrance so much as entrenched social mindsets and the powerful pull of the family unit. Qualified women appear more likely to be restrained at home than openly discriminated against at the employment office. For hundreds of millions of poorer women, moreover, change in India